in and around Varanasi. Some of them were carving lions to adorn homes and temples. Somehow, the new sculptures all have the characteristic ‘grin’ that one sees on the Mauryan lions. Is this conscious choice or just the unconscious weight of history?

Later rulers understood the symbolic meaning of the Mauryan columns and were always keen to appropriate them. This is why the emperors of the Gupta and Mughal dynasties, went out of their way to put their own inscriptions next to those of Ashoka. Feroze Shah Tughlaq, the fourteenth-century sultan of Delhi, even had two of the pillars shipped to his newly built palace complex. Therefore, it should not be surprising that, when India became independent, Mauryan lions and the chakra became the country’s national symbols. The founding fathers of the Indian Republic intuitively understood that the lions and the wheel stood for the power of the State. Indeed, Ashoka himself may have appropriated pre-existing symbolism. There are legends that associate Ashoka’s grandfather with lions. Scholars like John Irwin argue that some of the Ashokan columns may actually have been put up by his predecessors and that Ashoka had merely added his inscriptions to them! [26]

Ashoka ruled till he died at the age of seventy-two in 232 BC. The Mauryan empire collapsed soon after. Many arguments have been put forward to explain why the empire collapsed so quickly after Ashoka. There are those who feel that the emperor’s growing infatuation with Buddhist philosophy sapped the morale of the army and the administration. It is very difficult to say what exactly happened, but there is evidence that the empire had already begun to crumble in Ashoka’s later years. There are many stories about intra-family intrigues and feuds that left the ageing monarch increasingly powerless. In my view, the real problem was that Ashoka held on to power for too long. Despite his protestations about following the path of righteousness, he was unable to give up the trappings of power even when he was too feeble to rule effectively. Contrast this with the attitude of his grandfather and Chanakya, the founders of the empire. The problem of ageing rulers would haunt India through the centuries.